steps that were alarmist in the extreme. That the government should first hear of the unilateral Chinese ceasefire on the morning of 21 November through the media while its own embassy had known of it thirty-six hours earlier is yet another aspect of the events of 1962 that defy belief.

In the Western Theatre of operations, by first light on 20 October, all Indian positions had been vacated. The entire ridge of Gurung Hill, Paw Hill, Mugger Hill and all other support positions were abandoned. Later in the day, all heavy equipment including the tanks were formed into a convoy that left for Leh as the troops moved back to occupy their new defences. The Chinese shelled the column as it approached Tsaka-la, but fortunately only one vehicle was hit while the others got through. The Chinese made no attempt to follow the withdrawing Indians.

In NEFA, the Chinese did not cross the last ridge of what they called the foothills. By last light on 22 October, Tezpur was a ghost town and the North Bank was completely abandoned. Through the day Kaul had been flying endlessly with the IAF, frantically looking for survivors. Once it got dark, he went and stood at the end of the dispersal area, next to a parked Dakota that was earmarked to fly him to Gauhati. ‘There were no staff officers or ADCs. The whole atmosphere was depressingly calm. The silence was broken only by the croaking of frogs and chirping insects and the occasional sound of a helicopter taking off or landing far on the other side of the runway. It was a dismal sight of a Corps Commander, standing alone in the atmosphere of defeat—a broken man, on his own with no friends or sympathy.’

At around 6.30 in the evening, a helicopter landed with Major General Anant Pathania, GOC 4 Division, who had been picked up just before sunset. As those present on the tarmac watched, Pathania ‘slightly drooping, in a crumpled uniform, walking slowly with a long stick as high as himself, dragging his feet as if he was in no hurry and had no particular place in mind to go to’ moved towards Kaul, who was still standing there. When he was a few yards from Kaul, Pathania ‘came to a slow stop and looked up with a detached expression. He stood and looked up at him for a little while in this fashion and turned his face away as if the man in front of him was better left alone, and deserved no feelings of rancour or words of sympathy.’

On paper the Chinese said they were withdrawing to the line which was under their control prior to 8 September 1962 and would demilitarize the